

Kerama Backpackers

Morino-san

Morino-san looks tough, a little grumpy maybe, the kind of man you might hesitate to interrupt. Lean and strong, always wearing his sports sunglasses, he has the look of a professional cyclist. And yet, he is one of the kindest people I have met.

At heart, all he really wants is to be on the water, or on his boat, a beautiful fourteen-foot ship, simple and honest, just like him. A true Osaka man. A man of few words, but always ready for a pun, a quiet joke, or a sudden burst of absurd humor. One of my fondest memories is when he unexpectedly imitated the terrifying scream of a Tasmanian devil.

He loves his children deeply. A devoted, protective father, always attentive without ever being overbearing, present without needing to show it. His connection to the sea is so natural that he doesn't even like fishing, nor eating fish. He just likes to see them. I remember him telling me that very simply, that what mattered was watching them move, nothing more.

Sometimes I imagine his past life as a truck driver on the Kansai roads, long hours behind the wheel, his mind drifting elsewhere. I picture him driving endlessly, dreaming of the Kerama blue, of the Keramashoto sea. I'm certain that if it were possible, he would have driven his truck straight through the ocean.

He doesn't speak much. But when he does, it always matters.

Thank you, from the bottom of my heart. You are the one who offered me a place to stay without really knowing me. You met me once, and you welcomed me into this island, into your family, into your life.

That gesture alone says everything about the kind of man you are.

Know that I will always see you as a model, someone I look up to. A great father. A man who works hard for his dream, quietly, steadily. I respect you deeply, and I respect your family.

Thank you.

Miki-san

With Miki-san, food moved between us the way words often couldn't. A dish left on the table for me. A bowl covered carefully, saved for later. Something warm handed over without explanation, as if it didn't need one.

We cooked for each other. Not together, but toward one another. She would prepare something special and place it in front of me, watching closely, not to judge, just to see if it landed well. I tried to answer in my own way, Italian meals made with what I had, coffee prepared carefully, cookies that carried more intention than technique.

Recipes were exchanged loosely. Not written, not measured. Just described, approximated, trusted. Sometimes something worked. Often it didn't. It never mattered. What mattered was the gesture, the effort moving back and forth, the sense that giving was already enough.

In that rhythm of offerings, something settled between us. No big declarations. Just attention, care, and the quiet understanding that hospitality doesn't need to be explained when it's sincere.

I will always carry this with me, and I am deeply grateful to call you not only my host, but my friend.